REP-032 · Tweaks from the benchmark review: a readable price duel, three prototypes and the Market Gossip card

Game	Fruit Market (app on rules version 3; design target rules version 4, REP-031)
Report date	2026-10-27 14:34 (Asia/Kuala_Lumpur)
Type	Design proposal with lab checks. **Game code unchanged**
Input	The owner's benchmark review of REP-031 (Stockpile, Food Chain Magnate, Modern Art, For Sale, Catan, Monopoly) and the request: "suggest tweaks based on the above, dont take current game turn as the final form, feel free to tweak accordingly, introduce one favour cards which allows player to see the demand for the face down card"
Proposed plan	PLAN-015 (awaiting approval). It reshapes PLAN-014 before that is built

Labels. [Sim] = computer players: 600 games per test on unseen seeds, about ±4 points. **[Hyp]** = a guess about people, to test at the table.

Correction to REP-031. Food Chain Magnate does not simply give customers to the cheapest restaurant. Whether a restaurant can serve the order, price plus distance, and tie-breakers all matter. Thank you for the check.

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1. The direction

The review's main point holds: **make the price duel exciting and easy to read; don't add machinery.** The hook stays:

> **"How much can I charge before my rival, or the rot, gets me?"**

Every tweak below either:

- removes bookkeeping;
- makes the reveal clearer;
- gives a real alternative to "$1 lower"; or
- gives the session an arc.

The new favour card is the **only** new information mechanism, as the review advised.

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2. A new day: five beats instead of eight

Beat	What happens	Why
1. Dawn: the "Tomorrow" strip	The lorry unloads today's fruit. One strip shows everything known about tomorrow: the lorry card, the event, the expected customer (face up) and the walk-ins (face down, backs show their fruit)	All forecasting in one place, so there are no separate things to check
2. Market	Buy up to 4 fruits, poorest shop first	Unchanged
3. Open stalls *(new)*	Each shop puts the fruit it will sell today into its "for sale" crate, **face up**. Quantities are public before anyone prices	Makes the alternative to undercutting visible: "He only has two apples, so I can charge more and serve the rest"
4. The bell	Prices are set secretly on the price board, then **everyone reveals at once**. This is the centrepiece	One clear dramatic moment a day
5. The rush	Customers come in queue order; each fruit goes from the cheapest stall, and leftover demand **spills to the next stall**. Every sale is shown as customer → stall. Then night: fruit ages	Players see why they sold or didn't

Removed from the core:

- the market pulse track, now an optional advanced rule;
- evening admin on most days (upgrades are bought only on Market Day evenings, see section 4);
- the Haggler tie rule. Ties become **fresher fruit, then poorer shop**, which uses one catch-up idea, not three.

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3. Prototype A: the core market (readability)

Tweak	Change	Evidence
A1 **Uniform freshness**	Every fruit sells at full price when fresh, −$1 when okay, −$2 when not so. Fruits differ only in **how many nights** they stay in each stage. One rule replaces four price-drop tables	[Sim] Plans win 26–38% (was 25–42%); Hard beats Normal 56% (same); comebacks 32% (was 28%)
A2 **Street prices (option)**	Each fruit has one printed street price ($5 blueberry, $7 watermelon, $6 apple, $9 mango). Customer cards show only what and how many, plus a "generous" +$2 icon on a few cards	[Sim] Balanced (plans 25–43%), but skill matters a little less (Hard beats Normal 53%). Keep as the beginner option
A3 **Catch-up stays "poorest buys first"**	Keep cash order; don't switch to net worth	[Sim] Adversarial test: a shop that buys every upgrade wins 33% (fair), so there's no exploit. Ordering by net worth makes hoarding cash viable (13% → 32%) but makes upgrades optional, and it's harder to count by hand
A4 **Simpler ties**	Fresher fruit, then poorer shop	[Hyp] Fewer exceptions to remember

Prototype A without traits, favours and upgrades [Sim]:

- Games are close (17% blowouts).
- **Ripening green fruit dominates** (60% wins), and Hard beats Normal only 52%.
- The layers we're removing currently keep that plan in check. If people find it the same, Prototype B must fix it.

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4. Prototype B: different businesses (upgrades that change decisions)

There are four "stall specialities", one per plan. Each changes *what you do*, not just how much you earn.

Speciality	Cost	Effect	Decision it changes	Replaces
Cold Room	$5	Your fruit ages only every other night; Heatwave-proof	Hold stock for a shortage or Market Day	Cool Room ($7)
Juice Bar	$4	+$1 for each okay or not-so fruit sold; up to 3 spoiling fruits a night become $2 each	Buy cheap old fruit at the farmers market on purpose	Juice Press
Barrow	$6	Buy 5 a day and hold 12	Volume and turnover	Handcart + Bigger Shelf
Premium Display	$8	Your **fresh** fruit may be priced $1 above a customer's normal limit	Stay expensive, and sell to whoever is left after the cheap stalls run out	Signboard

- Removed: **Shop Bell** (the Market Gossip card takes over the information role).
- **When:** upgrades are drafted only on the evening after each Market Day (see section 5): three build moments a game, not ten.
- **Traits** stay as starting stall capabilities.
- [Hyp] The upgrades are designed to change decisions, so measure them by whether they change purchasing, holding and pricing, not only by win rate. The computer players need teaching before the lab can rate them.

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5. Prototype C: market rhythm (the arc)

Day (10-day game)	Rhythm
1–2	**Opening:** small crowds; learn the rivals
3	**Market Day:** +1 walk-in, **no lorry**; then the evening upgrade draft
4–5	Ordinary trading; demand grows
6	**Market Day**, then the draft
7–8	Second-half crowds (more walk-ins)
9	**Market Day**, then the last draft
10	**Last Call:** customers pay +$1; afterwards the jam maker buys leftover fruit at $1 each

Market Days are printed on the day track, so everyone knows they're coming. In 8-day games they fall on days 3 and 6; in 14-day games on 3, 6, 9 and 12.

- **Why:**
  - preparation, holding stock for a day with no lorry, becomes a planned, satisfying choice;
  - the jam maker softens the final-day dump without making stock valuable.
- [Sim] Market Days every third day:
  - plans become the most even of anything tested (24–35%);
  - comebacks rise to 38%;
  - spoilage halves.
- **But** Hard and Normal computers become even (50%), because the computers don't plan ahead.
- [Hyp] Following the review: lower spoilage is not automatically better. Test whether preparing creates hard choices, or just an obvious stock-up.
- A $1 jam-maker salvage was tested earlier: no balance change.

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6. The new favour card: **Market Gossip** 👂

> **Market Gossip** *(evening)*. Secretly look at the front of every face-down walk-in card in tomorrow's queue: who they are, what they want, how many, and their top price. Don't show anyone. Everyone sees that you played it.

- **Replaces Free Cash** (2 copies; the deck stays at 12). Free Cash is the only favour that is pure money with no decision.
- **Why it fits the review:**
  - it is the single, contained piece of private information that the review suggested;
  - rivals know you know *something*, and your buying gives clues ("why is she buying so many mangoes?");
  - that adds Stockpile-style reading without forecasts, secret objectives and trading all at once.
- **How it's earned:** like any favour, by serving a customer's whole order by yourself. It rewards the sales that build rivalry.
- **App:**
  - the walk-in silhouettes turn face up **only on your screen**, with a small 👂 badge on your seat for rivals;
  - online, the server must send the card fronts to that player only, the same privacy rule as secret prices, with a leak check added to the browser tests.
- **Needs:** the face-down queue (REP-031). It works whether or not the street-price option is used; with street prices it reveals quantities and "generous" icons.
- [Hyp] Test it on its own, after A–C, so its effect can be told apart (as the review advised).

Favour deck after the change (2 of each):

- Market Gossip *(new)*
- Free Fruit
- Good Riddance
- Fridge

- Favoured Trade
- Priority

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7. App feedback: understand why you won or lost

Feature	Status today	Tweak
Which customer bought from which stall	Showdown cards per line	One **"rush" view**: customers walk to the stalls they bought from
Why a sale was missed	Tags: "$1 too high", "lost tie: fresher won", "Right price, not enough stock"	Keep; add "too old for that price" (freshness)
Day's money in, money out and waste	Day income only	**Day ledger:** sales, purchases, spoilage and upgrades, with net for the day
Reveal pacing	Fast, skippable	A short pause after the bell before the rush resolves
Forecast and rival stock	Lorry strip, rival drop-downs, rivals strip while pricing	All in the one Tomorrow strip, plus the public "for sale" crates
Playtest modes	Toggles for events, upgrades, unripe	Add **"Core market" (Prototype A)** and **"Market Days"** toggles in the set-up, so playtests can compare versions

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8. Test plan (the review's targets)

Step	Version	Question	Measure
1	A (core) on paper and in the app	Is the core fun on its own?	Teach in ~5 minutes; new players finish unaided; players can explain their best and worst decision
2	B (specialities)	Does specialising improve rivalry and replay?	Did upgrades change what people bought, held or priced? Did a "stay expensive" win happen?
3	C (rhythm), on the better of A and B	Does preparation improve the arc?	Hard choices before Market Days; the final two days still have real decisions
4	+ Market Gossip	Does one private clue add reading?	Did anyone change their play after seeing a rival use Gossip?
Always	Same group repeatedly, plus fresh groups	Repetition and dominant plans; teaching problems	Replay requests; time per game; the reveals people remember

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9. What changes against the approved PLAN-014

PLAN-014 item	Proposal
Printed supply and demand, posted prices, crates, queue, fruit payouts	**Keep**
Market pulse in the core	Move to an **optional advanced rule**
Market Days optional	Make the rhythm **standard in Prototype C** (fixed days on the track)
Event redesign	Keep
Upgrades unchanged (retune)	Replace with the **four specialities**, drafted on Market Day evenings
Tie rules	Simplify to fresher, then poorer
Free Cash	Replace with **Market Gossip**

Lab files: `docs/workflow/reports/img/REP-032-lab.tar.gz` .